PRIMUS · MARKET SIMULATION

Problem statements and crises

Every problem statement and crisis card in the game, in detail, with what each one asks of the teams and how the answers are judged.

Luxury FMCG Energy

3	1	12	30
Round 1 problem statements, one per sector	Round 1 consulting case, the same for every firm	Round 2 crisis cards, four per sector	Round 3 problem statements, ten per sector

How to read this book. Text in a coloured box marked **On screen** is exactly what teams see in the game (it comes from the files the organisers upload: seed/sectors/problem-cards.csv, crisis-cards.csv and statements.csv). Everything around it is guidance for organisers, judges and mentors: what the card means, what a strong answer covers and what moves the market.

Fairness. All numbers on the cards are invented for the game and are the same for every company that receives the card. Real startups are named for inspiration only; teams must not copy them, and the judge scores the team's own plan.

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1 · How the night uses them

PRIMUS has three tracks. **Product** teams build a startup inside their sector and run it as a listed company. **Consulting** teams are firms that companies hire for advice. **Finance** teams are funds that invest in the companies and trade their shares. At the squad draw the lottery gives every squad one of the three sectors, in equal shares (17 Luxury, 17 FMCG and 16 Energy for 50 squads), and the squad keeps that sector all night.

Time	Round	What happens	What it moves
21:00	Squad draw	Each squad's sector is drawn and its problem card is set.	Who competes with whom all night
21:00–22:00	Round 1 · Foundation	**Product** writes a PRD for a startup inside its sector's problem statement (800 words, 7 sections). **Consulting** writes a memo on the Kaveri Fresh case (500 words, 6 sections).	The PRD score sets the IPO price; the memo score sets the firm's opening reputation and a bonus
by 22:30	Round 1	**Consulting** makes Call 1: BUY or SELL on each of its two companies. **Finance** reads the PRDs and bids in the IPO (until 22:45).	$2,500 per correct call; the opening share register
22:45 · 00:15 · 01:45 · 03:15	Round 2 · Pressure	Four crises. In crisis *k* every company gets its own sector's card number *k*: 1 Operations, 2 Market, 3 Trust, 4 Money.	Every price −5% at each reveal; then each plan's score moves its company's price
04:45	Round 3 · Saturation	Funds receive fresh capital. Companies draft one of their sector's ten statements and write a solution with a hired firm (600 words, 6 sections).	The solution score moves the price, shared between companies on the same statement
06:00 · 06:30 · 07:10	Close	Solutions due; the market closes; the awards.	Final rankings

One crisis, minute by minute

Minute	What happens
0	The crisis cards are revealed, one to each company (its sector's card *k*). Every price falls 5% and trading pauses for 5 minutes.
0–20	**Hiring.** The Product team sends offers (cash, shares or both) to consulting firms; firms accept, counter or decline. One firm per company, at most two clients per firm. Open offers lapse at minute 20.

20–65	**Writing.** The Product team writes its crisis plan (500 words, 7 sections); the hired firm writes its advice memo to the client (500 words, 4 sections). Both close at minute 65. The fee, held in escrow, is paid to the firm if its memo is in, and refunded otherwise.
65–80	**Rating.** The client rates its firm from 1 to 5 stars (a missing rating counts as 3). Plans are public; scores stay sealed.
80	**Release.** The plan's score moves the company's price. The firm earns a reputation bonus of $500 × (memo score − 50) + $1,000 × (stars − 3).
80–90	**Last trading window** of the crisis. It opens only once the plan scores are released.

Round 3 in short

The statements	Ten per sector, each open to at most 5 companies (room for 50 in every sector).
The draft	The lowest score so far (the PRD and the Round 2 plans, averaged) picks first, 20 seconds each, and only from its own sector's statements. A company that does not pick gets the least-crowded open statement.
Hiring	Firms post an asking fee; offers must be 5–20% of the company's cash; at most 3 counters; 2 clients per firm.
Saturation	On each statement, companies are ranked by score: the 1st gets its full price rise, the 2nd ×0.75, the 3rd ×0.5, the 4th and 5th ×0.25. Price falls apply in full. A company alone on its statement gets its full rise.

2 · Round 1 · The consulting case: Kaveri Fresh

Every Consulting firm, whatever its squad's sector, writes a recommendation memo on this one case, by 22:00. Because the case is the same for everyone, the memo score is a fair first measure of each firm, and it sets the reputation companies see when they hire in Round 2.

ON SCREEN · THE CASE

Kaveri Fresh: the cold room is gone

Kaveri Fresh is a Bengaluru start-up that delivers fruit and vegetables from 40 farms to 220 restaurants. It has 35 staff, ₹1.2 crore in the bank and makes ₹18 lakh a month in gross profit on ₹1.5 crore of sales. On Monday its only cold-storage partner, which holds 60% of its stock overnight, shut without notice after a fire. Kaveri has no other cold room. Without one it can keep only a day's stock in its six refrigerated vans, and about a third of what it buys spoils. Two of its five largest customers, who together bring 30% of sales, say they will switch suppliers if deliveries are late for a second week. A new cold room of its own would cost ₹45 lakh and take three months to build; renting space elsewhere costs about twice the old rate and the nearest site is 25 km further from the city. The founders want one recommendation by Friday.

The facts at a glance

The business	Bengaluru start-up delivering fruit and vegetables from 40 farms to 220 restaurants; 35 staff.
Money	₹1.2 crore in the bank; ₹18 lakh a month gross profit on ₹1.5 crore of sales.
What happened	On Monday its only cold-storage partner, holding 60% of its stock overnight, shut after a fire.
Without a cold room	Only a day's stock fits in its six refrigerated vans, and about a third of what it buys spoils.
Customers at risk	Two of its five largest customers, 30% of sales together, will switch if deliveries are late a second week.
Options in the case	Its own cold room: ₹45 lakh and three months to build. Rented space: about twice the old rate, and 25 km further from the city.
Deadline	The founders want one recommendation by Friday.

The memo (500 words) has six sections: diagnosis · options and trade-offs · recommendation · the numbers · risks · next steps. The judge scores them out of 25, 20, 20, 15, 10 and 10 (Appendix A).

What a strong memo does

- **Diagnosis:** names the root cause (one storage partner and no backup) and what it costs each week: the spoilage, and the two customers bringing 30% of sales, about ₹45 lakh of a ₹1.5 crore month.
- **Options:** compares at least two options on cost, time and risk, and pairs a short-term bridge (this week) with the long-term fix (the next three months).
- **Recommendation:** makes one clear choice that follows from the analysis, and says what it gives up and why that is acceptable.
- **Numbers:** works out the costs and the money at risk correctly, and checks that the plan fits ₹1.2 crore of cash.
- **Risks and next steps:** a plan for each main risk, and this week's actions with owners and dates.

The standard is what a strong student team can write in under an hour.

SECTION 3 · SECTOR

Luxury

Reengineering the next era of luxury · problem card 1 of 3 · about 17 squads of 50

Luxury is moving beyond owning rare products towards personalised services, experiences, access and proof of authenticity. The sector's value rests on desirability and trust, so counterfeits, scandals, a generation's changing tastes or an economic downturn hit valuations hard. That makes luxury a natural test of brand judgement for Consulting firms and of conviction for Finance teams.

Round 1 · The problem statement

ON SCREEN · PROBLEM CARD 1

Reengineering the next era of luxury

The global luxury ecosystem is undergoing a fundamental transformation, moving beyond conventional paradigms of ownership, exclusivity and status towards hyper-personalisation, intelligent services and immersive experiences. Despite rapid market evolution, significant gaps persist in how luxury is conceptualised, delivered, accessed and sustained. From fragmented consumer journeys and underdeveloped experiential ecosystems to inefficient service infrastructure and evolving expectations of affluent consumers, the industry presents substantial opportunities for disruption. How might we leverage emerging business models, technological innovation and unconventional value propositions to architect the next generation of luxury products, services and experiences, transforming premium living into an entirely new market opportunity?

Every Product team in this sector invents its own startup inside this statement and describes it in its PRD (800 words, 7 sections: problem and target user, proposed solution, core features and MVP scope, success metrics, business model, competitive edge, key risks).

Opportunity areas

A · Experiences and hospitality

- Hyper-personalised luxury travel and hospitality
- Exclusive, curated experiences and private memberships
- Luxury concierge and lifestyle management platforms
- Immersive hospitality and destination-based experiences
- Personalised premium wellness and leisure services

B · Intelligent luxury and personalisation

- AI-powered personal shopping assistants
- Predictive consumer preference platforms
- Bespoke product customisation and manufacturing
- Intelligent wardrobe and lifestyle management
- Personalised luxury recommendations and discovery

C · Ownership and accessibility

- Alternative ownership and fractional luxury models
- Premium asset-sharing ecosystems
- Verified luxury resale and authentication platforms
- Subscription-based access to premium products
- Luxury rental and circular ownership models

D · Infrastructure and services

- Smart luxury residences and intelligent living spaces
- Integrated property and lifestyle management
- Automated premium customer service infrastructure
- Exclusive mobility and transportation services
- Digital ecosystems connecting luxury service providers

E · Sustainability and responsible luxury

- Sustainable luxury material innovation
- Product lifecycle and traceability solutions

F · Brand innovation and engagement

- Next-generation luxury loyalty ecosystems
- Digital identity and authenticity verification

- Premium repair, restoration and refurbishment services
- Circular luxury commerce
- Ethical sourcing and supply-chain transparency
- Experiential brand engagement platforms
- New-age luxury communities and private networks
- Innovative brand extension and monetisation models

Real-world challenges

Challenge	Why it matters
The exclusivity dilemma	Expanding the customer base without diluting scarcity, prestige and brand equity.
The personalisation gap	Experiences are fragmented across stores, apps, hotels and personal services instead of one intelligent, personal ecosystem.
The authenticity crisis	Sophisticated counterfeits and a growing resale market undermine provenance and confidence.
The ownership paradigm shift	Access, flexibility, experiences and sharing challenge the model of owning products.
The after-sales deficit	Repair, warranty, maintenance and restoration are fragmented and inconsistent.
The brand extension dilemma	Moving into hospitality, wellness or real estate risks complexity and dilution.
The sustainability paradox	Premium, resource-heavy production must meet ethical sourcing and circular expectations.

Startups for inspiration

- Aura Blockchain Consortium: Digital certificates of authenticity and ownership for luxury goods.
- Vestiaire Collective / The RealReal: Authenticated luxury resale.
- Rent the Runway: Subscription and rental access to designer fashion.
- Quintessentially: Members-only lifestyle concierge.
- Kapture-style clienteling tools: Software that lets luxury stores know and serve each client personally.

Named for inspiration only: teams must not copy them, and the judge scores the team's own plan.

An illustrative concept: LUXORA. The operating system for luxury living: one digital ecosystem that connects affluent consumers with personalised lifestyle services, premium experiences, exclusive memberships, luxury property management, private travel and concierge services, and anticipates their preferences instead of making them deal with many separate providers. This is one interpretation; other teams could build luxury hardware, sustainable materials, premium hospitality, authentication technology or new ownership models.
How it could make money: Premium annual memberships; Commission-based service partnerships; Exclusive brand collaborations; B2B partnerships with luxury hospitality and real estate companies; Personalised concierge subscriptions.

What a strong PRD shows in this sector

- The client segment (new-money professionals, NRIs, the ultra-rich, aspirational buyers) and what they lack today
- Why it is luxury: scarcity, craft, service or access, not just a higher price
- How trust is earned: authentication, privacy, service quality
- Unit economics per member, item or experience
- Success metrics such as members retained, spend per client, resale value kept or authentication accuracy

Round 2 · The four crisis cards

In crisis *k*, every Luxury company receives card *k* below, so all of them face the same numbers and can be compared fairly. The plan (500 words) is due 65 minutes after the reveal.

1 OPERATIONS The digital identity breach

ON SCREEN

> A premium lifestyle platform you depend on is breached: the purchase histories and private profiles of 40,000 high-net-worth clients leak. Several cancel their memberships and the press names your brand.

ON THE CARD

- 40,000 high-net-worth clients' profiles and purchase histories leaked
- The breach is at a partner platform, but the press names your brand
- Members are already cancelling

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Discretion is part of what luxury clients pay for, so a leak hits trust, retention and the brand's name at once, and it exposes how much the company depends on an outside platform.

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Separate what the company controls (its own data, its words, its service) from what it does not (the partner's systems); set the order of the first 72 hours; price retention offers against what a top client is worth.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Protect clients first: tell the people affected, secure their accounts, reach out personally to the most valuable
- Rebuild confidentiality: what data the company holds, who can see it, what changes now
- Reduce dependence on the breached platform, and cost the switch
- Estimate the revenue at risk (memberships cancelled and spending lost) against the cost of the response

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

How many members cancel and how many stay, how fast and how honestly the company responds, and its dependence on outside platforms.

2 MARKET The experience economy disruption

ON SCREEN

> A disruptive startup offers ultra-personalised premium experiences without ownership. 20% of your clients shift spending to it within a quarter and engagement with your products falls.

ON THE CARD

- A startup sells ultra-personalised experiences without ownership
- 20% of your clients move spending to it within a quarter
- Engagement with your products falls

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Revenue from a fifth of clients is at risk and the shift may spread; the company has to decide whether it sells products, access or experiences.

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Find out which clients left and why; test one experience offer quickly before a big bet; protect what the rival cannot copy, such as craft, heritage and personal service.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Decide between partnering with, acquiring, copying or differentiating from the rival
- Add experiences only where they fit the brand
- Show the value of each option: revenue kept or won against what it costs
- Say how you will know within weeks whether the clients are coming back

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

Whether the lost clients return, what the new offer costs, and whether the brand stays premium.

3 TRUST The counterfeit revolution

ON SCREEN

> Hyper-realistic counterfeits made with advanced manufacturing flood the market. Even experts cannot tell them apart; resale prices of authentic pieces fall 30% and returns from buyers who fear fakes rise 4×.

ON THE CARD

- Hyper-realistic counterfeits that even experts cannot tell apart
- Resale prices of authentic pieces fall 30%
- Returns from buyers who fear fakes rise 4×

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Resale value supports the price new buyers will pay; when nobody can prove what is genuine, both the resale market and new sales suffer.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Prove authenticity: digital IDs, verified resale, guarantees
- Handle the returns now and reassure existing clients
- Protect resale value of genuine pieces
- Cost the programme against the sales at risk

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Choose a verification method clients will trust and that can be rolled out quickly; decide who pays for it; set a fair returns policy for the buyers who are worried today.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

Resale prices and return rates after the response, and the cost and speed of the authentication rollout.

4 MONEY The luxury market crash

ON SCREEN

> A sudden downturn cuts discretionary spending: luxury retail falls 18%, high-end hospitality bookings 25% and luxury real estate deals 30%. Your next funding round is postponed.

ON THE CARD

- Luxury retail falls 18%
- High-end hospitality bookings fall 25%
- Luxury real estate deals fall 30%
- Your next funding round is postponed

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Revenue falls just as outside money stops, so the cash runway becomes the main constraint.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Protect cash without discounting the brand
- Focus on the most loyal clients and delay expansion
- Find revenue that holds up in a downturn (services, maintenance, top clients)
- Show the runway in months under the card's falls

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Model the runway with the card's numbers; rank cost cuts by how much they damage the brand; name the revenue that survives a downturn.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

Months of runway, whether the company discounts (which damages the brand) or holds its prices, and how many top clients it keeps.

Spare cards

Not loaded in the game. Use one to replace a card before the draw, in a rehearsal, or as a mid-round surprise announced in a bulletin.

- The sustainability scandal: a report exposes unethical sourcing and excessive resource use across several high-end brands, including one of your suppliers
- The next-gen exodus: research shows younger affluent buyers moving to niche labels and independent creators; your under-35 sales fall 22%
- Mid-round surprise: a company that looked safe is itself put under investigation for counterfeit components
- An influencer you paid is exposed for fake reviews
- A 20% rise in import duty on luxury goods

Round 3 · The ten problem statements

Each statement takes at most 5 companies. A Luxury company drafts only from this list, and writes its solution (600 words, 6 sections: our solution, why it fits the statement, how we stand apart, how we will build it, business impact, risks) with the firm it hires. The game shows each statement as its title with the line "Luxury · Round 3. … Design the solution, how it is delivered and how it is measured."

#	Statement (on screen)	A strong solution shows
1	**Expand to new clients without losing exclusivity** Up to 5 companies	Who the new clients are, how access stays scarce (invitations, limits, tiers), and how you measure that existing clients do not leave or spend less.
2	**One personal assistant for a client's whole luxury life** Up to 5 companies	Which needs it brings together (travel, shopping, homes, events), how it learns preferences while keeping data private, and what clients pay for it.
3	**Prove any luxury item is genuine in seconds** Up to 5 companies	How an item is checked at the point of sale or resale, who pays, what happens to items already in circulation, and the error rate you can promise.
4	**Fractional ownership of art, cars or watches** Up to 5 companies	Which assets, how shares are bought, held and sold, who looks after the asset, and how owners get value from it, within the rules.
5	**After-sales care as good as the purchase** Up to 5 companies	Repair, maintenance and restoration as one service: turnaround times, quality control, and how it keeps clients loyal and spending.
6	**Turn a fashion brand into a hospitality experience** Up to 5 companies	The experience (hotel, club, café, events), how it fits the brand without diluting it, and the economics per guest or member.
7	**Luxury materials that are fully traceable and sustainable** Up to 5 companies	Which material, how every step is traced and proven, the premium clients will pay, and how the claims are checked independently.
8	**Win the next generation of luxury buyers** Up to 5 companies	Who these buyers are and what they value, the product and channel that reach them, and measures such as first purchases and repeat rate.
9	**Private, secure data for high-net-worth clients** Up to 5 companies	What data is protected, how clients control it, how breaches are prevented and handled, and why clients would pay for it.
10	**Circular luxury: repair, resell and refurbish at scale** Up to 5 companies	How items come back, are authenticated, restored and resold; the margin per item; and how it protects the brand's prices.

What Finance teams should watch in this sector

Signal	Why
Brand equity	Pricing power and resale value are the signals.
Client concentration	How much revenue the top clients bring.
Authenticity exposure	Risk from counterfeits and the resale market.
Sensitivity to downturns	Discretionary spending falls first.
Reputation risk	Scandals and breaches travel fast among wealthy clients.

SECTION 4 · SECTOR

FMCG

Fast-moving consumer goods · problem card 2 of 3 · about 17 squads of 50

FMCG covers the everyday products people buy again and again: food, drinks, personal care and household goods. The sector runs on thin margins, huge volumes and long distribution chains that reach millions of small shops. That makes every problem, from spoilt stock to a viral complaint, show up quickly in sales and margins, which is exactly what the game needs.

Round 1 · The problem statement

ON SCREEN · PROBLEM CARD 2

Fast-moving consumer goods

The FMCG industry is undergoing a significant transformation as consumers increasingly demand healthier products, greater transparency, sustainability, personalized experiences, and seamless product availability. However, many companies continue to struggle with understanding rapidly changing consumer preferences, optimizing supply chains, reducing product wastage, ensuring efficient last-mile distribution, and building trust through authentic and transparent practices. Design an innovative startup that addresses one or more of these interconnected challenges to help FMCG businesses become more consumer-centric, operationally efficient, sustainable, and future-ready.

Every Product team in this sector invents its own startup inside this statement and describes it in its PRD (800 words, 7 sections: problem and target user, proposed solution, core features and MVP scope, success metrics, business model, competitive edge, key risks).

Opportunity areas

Demand and retail intelligence

- Forecasting for festivals, seasons and local tastes
- Inventory tools for small retailers and distributors
- Shelf and price analytics for modern trade and quick commerce

Supply chain and last mile

- Cold chain for fresh and frozen food
- Route and fleet optimisation
- Reaching rural shops profitably

Healthier and honest products

- Better-for-you food at mass prices
- Clear labels and ingredient traceability
- Personalised nutrition

Sustainability

- Plastic-free and refill packaging
- Food-waste reduction and recovery
- Traceable, ethical sourcing

Real-world challenges

Challenge	Why it matters
Fast-changing tastes	Preferences shift by city, season and social media trend faster than plants and supply chains can follow.
Waste and spoilage	Perishable stock is lost at every step from farm to shelf, eating into thin margins.
The last mile	Millions of small shops order little and often; serving them profitably is hard.
Trust	Consumers doubt health and sustainability claims, and one viral post can undo years of branding.
Channel dependence	Quick-commerce apps and big retailers control shelf space, data and pricing power.

Startups for inspiration

- Bizom (India): Retail intelligence, inventory optimisation and demand forecasting for fragmented distribution.
- Locus (India): AI logistics and last-mile route optimisation.
- RELEX Solutions: Demand forecasting and inventory optimisation across online and offline channels.
- Licious (India): Fresh food supply chain sold direct to consumers.
- Provenance: Product traceability and sustainability verification.
- Crisp: Retail analytics and consumer insights.

Named for inspiration only: teams must not copy them, and the judge scores the team's own plan.

An illustrative concept: FRESHLOOP. A demand-sensing and redistribution platform for perishable FMCG. It forecasts each shop's sales by day, moves near-expiry stock to shops or channels that will sell it, and donates or recycles what is left.
How it could make money: Software subscription from brands and distributors; A share of the waste saved; Data products for retail chains.

What a strong PRD shows in this sector

- A specific user (a brand, a distributor, a shop owner or a shopper) and the pain in numbers
- A first version small enough to launch in one city or one category
- Unit economics: cost and margin per unit, order or shop
- How it reaches shops or shoppers, and who pays
- Success metrics such as waste %, fill rate, repeat purchase or margin

Round 2 · The four crisis cards

In crisis *k*, every FMCG company receives card *k* below, so all of them face the same numbers and can be compared fairly. The plan (500 words) is due 65 minutes after the reveal.

1 OPERATIONS Heatwave breaks the cold chain

ON SCREEN

> A 46°C heatwave hits North India. Your cold chain fails in 3 cities: 18% of this week's stock spoils and 2,400 customers post complaints. Refunds cost Rs 41 lakh.

ON THE CARD

- A 46°C heatwave in North India
- The cold chain fails in 3 cities
- 18% of this week's stock spoils
- 2,400 customers complain; refunds cost Rs 41 lakh

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

A loss this week (stock and refunds) and a hit to reputation, with more hot weeks likely to come.

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Separate the immediate fix (backup storage, new routes, night deliveries) from the lasting one (a cold chain that survives heat); compare its cost with the Rs 41 lakh already lost.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Protect the stock that is left first, then the customers
- Decide who gets refunds and how fast
- Change storage and routes so the next heatwave hurts less
- Price the fix against the loss on the card

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

How fast the losses stop, whether complaints fall, and the cost of the fix against the margin.

2 MARKET A giant gives it away free

ON SCREEN

> A quick-commerce giant launches a free version of your core product or service for its partners. 22% of your customers say they will switch within a month.

ON THE CARD

- A quick-commerce giant gives away a free version of your core product or service to its partners
- 22% of your customers say they will switch within a month

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Competition at a price of zero: losing a fifth of customers in a month would hit revenue and the growth story.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Find what the free version cannot do
- Defend the customers who value that most
- Choose between partnering, narrowing to a niche or competing on price, with the cost of each
- Track how many customers actually leave against the 22% threat

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Identify the customers most likely to switch and why others would stay; set a ceiling on what retention may cost; consider working with the giant rather than against it.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

Actual churn against the 22% threat, and the margin after any price response.

3 TRUST Fake sustainability data

ON SCREEN

> A journalist shows that a key supplier faked its 'plastic-free' and 'organic' data, which you printed on your packs. #Greenwashing trends with your name in it.

ON THE CARD

- A key supplier faked its 'plastic-free' and 'organic' data
- Your packs carry those claims
- #Greenwashing trends with your name in it

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Shoppers and retailers now doubt every claim the company makes; retailers or regulators may act; the supplier has become a liability.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Own it quickly and say what was wrong
- Pull or relabel the packs that carry false claims
- Verify suppliers independently and show the proof
- Estimate the cost and the sales at risk

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Get the first statement and its timing right; bring in independent audits; decide what to do with the supplier; rebuild each claim only with proof.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

The speed and honesty of the response, how retailers react, and the cost of relabelling and audits.

4 MONEY Raw materials up 30%

ON SCREEN

> Palm oil, packaging and fuel costs rise 30% in a quarter. Your gross margin falls from 34% to 21%, and your next funding round is now in doubt.

ON THE CARD

- Palm oil, packaging and fuel costs rise 30% in a quarter
- Gross margin falls from 34% to 21%
- Your next funding round is in doubt

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Over a third of the margin is gone, and with funding in doubt the company must live on its own cash flow.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Choose between price rises, smaller packs, cheaper inputs and cost cuts
- Say which products to protect and which to cut
- Show the margin you expect after the plan
- Show the cash runway under the chosen plan

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Test what shoppers will accept (a higher price or a smaller pack); renegotiate or switch inputs; rank products by margin; show the path back towards 34%.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

The margin after the plan, how many sales the price rise costs, and the runway.

Spare cards

Not loaded in the game. Use one to replace a card before the draw, in a rehearsal, or as a mid-round surprise announced in a bulletin.

- A quick-commerce app changes its ranking algorithm: your products drop off the first screen and sales fall 28%
- A product recall: one batch fails a food-safety test in 2 states
- A cyberattack locks your ordering system for 3 days during peak season
- Privacy rules stop you using purchase data for personalisation
- Your largest enterprise client (34% of revenue) does not renew

Round 3 · The ten problem statements

Each statement takes at most 5 companies. An FMCG company drafts only from this list, and writes its solution (600 words, 6 sections: our solution, why it fits the statement, how we stand apart, how we will build it, business impact, risks) with the firm it hires. The game shows each statement as its title with the line "FMCG · Round 3. … Design the solution, how it is delivered and how it is measured."

#	Statement (on screen)	A strong solution shows
11	**Cut fresh-food waste from 9% to 3% across the supply chain** Up to 5 companies	Where in the chain the waste happens, the tool or process that removes it (forecasting, routing, redistribution), and the saving per tonne or per shop.
12	**Reach 50,000 rural kirana shops profitably** Up to 5 companies	The ordering and delivery model, the cost per drop against the order size, how shops pay, and how you reach the first 1,000 shops.
13	**Plastic-free packaging that costs under Rs 1 more per pack** Up to 5 companies	The material, its cost per pack at scale, shelf life and supply, and the proof that it is plastic-free.
14	**Honest health labels shoppers actually read** Up to 5 companies	The label or tool, how claims are checked, and evidence that shoppers notice it and change what they buy.

#	Statement (on screen)	A strong solution shows
15	**Forecast festival demand within 10% across city types** Up to 5 companies	The data used (sales, retailer orders, weather, local events), how accuracy is measured and improved, and what better forecasts save.
16	**Win shelf space on quick-commerce apps against big brands** Up to 5 companies	How a smaller brand gets ranked and stocked, what it offers the app, and the cost of each order won.
17	**Make healthy snacks affordable under Rs 20** Up to 5 companies	The product, its cost and margin at Rs 20 or less per pack, and how it reaches mass-market shops.
18	**Trace every ingredient from farm to pack in seconds** Up to 5 companies	How data is captured at each step, who enters it, how it is verified, and what brands and shoppers see.
19	**Return and refill systems for household products** Up to 5 companies	How containers come back and are refilled, the cost per refill against a new pack, and the return rate needed to break even.
20	**Personalised nutrition for India's diabetic population** Up to 5 companies	Who the users are, how advice or products are personalised, how outcomes are tracked safely, and who pays.

What Finance teams should watch in this sector

Signal	Why
Margin per unit	Does the plan protect it after a cost shock?
Wastage %	A falling number is a strong buy signal.
Acquisition cost vs repeat rate	Repeat buyers make FMCG profitable.
Channel dependence	One app or retailer holding most sales is a risk.
Cash runway	Months of cash left at the current burn.

SECTION 5 · SECTOR

Energy

Clean energy and power · problem card 3 of 3 · about 16 squads of 50

India must add a great deal of power capacity this decade while cutting emissions. Rooftop solar, EV charging, batteries and smart grids are growing fast, but they depend on subsidies, imported hardware and a grid that struggles at peak times. Policy changes and price swings hit these businesses hard and visibly, which gives funds clear signals to trade on.

Round 1 · The problem statement

ON SCREEN · PROBLEM CARD 3

Clean energy and power

The energy transition is reshaping how power is produced, stored, distributed and used. Rooftop solar, electric mobility, batteries and smart grids are growing fast, yet customers find clean energy costly and confusing, grids struggle with peak demand and outages, hardware supply chains are fragile, and businesses cannot measure or reduce their emissions with confidence. Design an innovative startup that makes clean energy cheaper, more reliable, easier to adopt or easier to measure, for homes, businesses, farms or cities, while remaining commercially viable without permanent subsidies.

Every Product team in this sector invents its own startup inside this statement and describes it in its PRD (800 words, 7 sections: problem and target user, proposed solution, core features and MVP scope, success metrics, business model, competitive edge, key risks).

Opportunity areas

Generation and storage

- Rooftop and community solar
- Batteries suited to Indian heat
- Storage for farms and cold chains

Electric mobility

- Charging networks for cities and highways
- Battery swapping for two- and three-wheelers
- Fleet electrification for delivery companies

Grid and demand

- Peak-demand reduction and smart tariffs
- Paying consumers to save or shift power
- Microgrids for villages and campuses

Carbon and circularity

- Carbon accounting for small factories
- Recycling batteries and panels
- Green power for data centres and industry

Real-world challenges

Challenge	Why it matters
Upfront cost	Clean energy saves money over years but costs a lot on day one.
Subsidy dependence	Many business cases work only while subsidies last.
Hardware supply	Panels, cells and chips are largely imported and swing in price.
Reliability	Heat, dust and grid outages shorten equipment life and break promises to customers.
Safety and trust	Battery fires and installer quality problems make customers wary.

Startups for inspiration

- SolarSquare (India): Rooftop solar for homes on easy monthly payments.
- Statiq (India): EV charging network for cities and highways.
- Log9 Materials (India): Fast-charging batteries for Indian conditions.

- Octopus Energy (UK): Software-led energy retail with smart tariffs.
- Sinai Technologies: Carbon accounting for industry.

Named for inspiration only: teams must not copy them, and the judge scores the team's own plan.

An illustrative concept: SUNSHARE. Community solar for apartment blocks and renters. Residents buy shares of a shared rooftop or nearby plant through an app and see the savings on their power bill.
How it could make money: A margin on each share sold; A monthly service fee; Selling surplus power to the grid.

What a strong PRD shows in this sector

- Who adopts it and what they pay today for power, fuel or carbon
- The payback period with and without subsidies
- How the hardware is sourced, installed and maintained
- Safety and reliability in Indian conditions
- Success metrics such as cost per unit of power, uptime or tonnes of carbon saved

Round 2 · The four crisis cards

In crisis *k*, every Energy company receives card *k* below, so all of them face the same numbers and can be compared fairly. The plan (500 words) is due 65 minutes after the reveal.

1 OPERATIONS Grid blackout in peak summer

ON SCREEN

> A 9-hour blackout across 4 states. Your systems or stations go offline, 30% of customers miss service, and penalty clauses cost Rs 55 lakh.

ON THE CARD

- A 9-hour blackout across 4 states
- Your systems or stations go offline
- 30% of customers miss service
- Penalty clauses cost Rs 55 lakh

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Penalties now, and the promise of reliable power is broken in front of customers.

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Set the order of restoration; handle the penalty clauses (credits, renegotiation); weigh the cost of backup against the expected cost of future outages.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Restore service in order of customer impact
- Communicate clearly during and after the outage
- Design backup or islanding so the next blackout hurts less
- Cost the backup against the penalties and lost customers

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

Penalties paid, customers lost, and what the backup investment costs.

2 MARKET Cheap imports flood the market

ON SCREEN

> Solar panels and batteries from abroad drop 25% in price. Your hardware now costs more than rivals' and two big orders are cancelled.

ON THE CARD

- Imported solar panels and batteries drop 25% in price
- Your hardware now costs more than rivals'
- Two big orders are cancelled

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

The hardware margin and the order book are hit together, and competing on price alone may not work.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Compete where imports are weak: service, warranty, financing, installation quality
- Or change suppliers, and say what that does to quality and margin
- Try to win back the cancelled orders
- Show the new margin

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Decide between switching to imported components and moving up to services; say what would win back the two orders; work out the new unit economics.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

The margin after the response, and whether the order book recovers.

3 TRUST A battery fire goes viral

ON SCREEN

> A video of a battery fire at a customer site gets 4 million views. The fire was not proven to be yours, but bookings fall 40% and a regulator asks for safety data.

ON THE CARD

- A battery-fire video at a customer site gets 4 million views
- The fire was not proven to be yours
- Bookings fall 40%
- A regulator asks for safety data

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

Fear spreads faster than facts: sales drop and the regulator starts asking questions.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Be transparent, and cooperate with the regulator
- Publish safety evidence
- Offer free inspections to customers
- Estimate the cost of rebuilding bookings

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Say what to state (and not to state) before the facts are known; commission an independent safety review; choose reassurance that customers value; cost it all.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

Whether bookings recover, the regulator's response, and the cost of inspections.

4 MONEY Subsidy cut overnight

ON SCREEN

> The government cuts the subsidy your customers rely on from Rs 30,000 to Rs 10,000. Your payback pitch of 4 years becomes 6.5 years.

ON THE CARD

- The subsidy your customers rely on falls from Rs 30,000 to Rs 10,000
- Your payback pitch of 4 years becomes 6.5 years

WHAT IT DOES TO THE COMPANY

The main selling point, the payback period, gets much worse overnight; demand falls; the business case leaned on policy.

A STRONG CRISIS PLAN

- Rebuild the offer without the subsidy
- Options: financing, smaller systems, a new customer segment
- Show the payback customers will now see
- Show the runway

THE HIRED FIRM'S ADVICE SHOULD

Work out the customer's payback under each option (financing, a smaller system, business customers); name the segment that still buys; show the runway.

WHAT FUNDS WILL WATCH

How much of the business depends on subsidies, the new payback offered, and orders after the cut.

Spare cards

Not loaded in the game. Use one to replace a card before the draw, in a rehearsal, or as a mid-round surprise announced in a bulletin.

- A lithium price spike raises battery costs 40%
- A new rule requires local manufacturing for subsidy eligibility
- A cyberattack takes over smart meters in one city
- Your main installer partner goes bankrupt
- A heatwave cuts panel output 15% for a month

Round 3 · The ten problem statements

Each statement takes at most 5 companies. An Energy company drafts only from this list, and writes its solution (600 words, 6 sections: our solution, why it fits the statement, how we stand apart, how we will build it, business impact, risks) with the firm it hires. The game shows each statement as its title with the line "Energy · Round 3. … Design the solution, how it is delivered and how it is measured."

#	Statement (on screen)	A strong solution shows
21	**Rooftop solar for renters and apartment blocks** Up to 5 companies	How residents who do not own the roof take part, how savings are shared and billed, and the payback for each resident.
22	**EV charging on highways that pays for itself in 3 years** Up to 5 companies	Where the chargers go and why, the cost per charger, the use needed for a 3-year payback, and every revenue stream.
23	**Batteries that survive Indian summers for 10 years** Up to 5 companies	The chemistry or cooling design, the testing that proves it, the warranty you can offer, and the cost per kWh over the battery's life.
24	**Carbon tracking a small factory can afford** Up to 5 companies	What it measures and how, the monthly price a small factory can pay, and how tracking turns into savings.
25	**Cutting peak-hour demand without blackouts** Up to 5 companies	How demand is moved or reduced at peak (tariffs, storage, smart devices), who is paid for it, and how much peak demand it removes.

#	Statement (on screen)	A strong solution shows
26	**Clean cooking for 20 crore rural homes** Up to 5 companies	The stove or fuel, its price and running cost against today's fuel, how it reaches villages, and how families keep using it.
27	**Recycling used EV and solar batteries** Up to 5 companies	How batteries are collected, tested and recycled or reused, the value recovered per battery, and how they are handled safely.
28	**Green power for cold storage on farms** Up to 5 companies	The power system (solar, storage), the cold storage it runs, the cost per farmer, and the produce it saves from spoiling.
29	**Paying households for power they save** Up to 5 companies	How savings are measured, how households are paid and by whom, and why the grid or the utility gains from it.
30	**Clean energy for 24/7 data centres** Up to 5 companies	How the power stays clean around the clock (storage, contracts, the mix), the cost per unit against grid power, and the proof behind the carbon claims.

What Finance teams should watch in this sector

Signal	Why
Subsidy dependence	How much of the business case survives a policy change.
Payback period	What customers are promised, and whether it holds.
Hardware cost vs imports	Exposure to global price swings.
Safety record	One incident can stop sales.
Debt and runway	Energy projects borrow heavily.

Appendix A · How every answer is judged

The AI judge scores each submission three times against these rubrics (five times if the three differ by more than 10 points) and keeps the median. Names are hidden, so every team is judged by the same standard. A score is out of 100.

Round 1 · The PRD (Product, 800 words)

Line	What earns points	Max
Problem	A specific problem, the user who has it, how many people have it and what it costs them today	**20**
Solution	A solution that clearly fixes that problem, with a small first version (MVP) whose core features are named and in scope	**20**
Metrics	Measurable signs of success, with targets and a time frame, that show whether the product works	**15**
Business model	Who pays, how much and how often, and whether that revenue can cover the costs	**15**
Feasibility	Whether a small team could build and run it with its seed money, why it beats the alternatives, and the main risks with a plan for each	**15**
Clarity	A PRD that is well organised, specific and easy to act on, with no filler	**15**

Round 1 · The consulting memo (Consulting, 500 words)

Line	What earns points	Max
Diagnosis	What went wrong, why it matters and what it costs Kaveri each week, using the case's facts	**25**
Options	Two or more real options, with what each one costs, gains and risks	**20**
Recommendation	One clear choice that follows from the diagnosis and options, with the reason	**20**
Numbers	Costs, revenue at risk, cash and timing that are correct and add up	**15**
Risks	What could go wrong with the recommendation and how to reduce it	**10**
Next steps	Concrete actions for this week, with who does them and by when	**10**

Round 2 · The crisis plan (Product, 500 words)

Sections: the crisis and what it does to us · our response · the money · what we take from our consultant · time to recovery · new risks · next steps.

Line	What earns points	Max
Solves the crisis	Deals directly with this crisis card and keeps the business serving its users	**25**
Money logic	Costs, revenue lost and cash needed that are believable and add up	**20**
Consultant's advice	Uses the firm's advice where it is good, says why where it is not	**15**
Time to recovery	A believable timeline back to normal, with milestones	**15**
New risks	Few new risks, and those named with a plan (fewer and better handled scores higher)	**15**
Next steps	Clear, practical steps for the next few days, with owners	**10**

Rounds 2 and 3 · The advice memo (the hired firm, 500 words)

Sections: diagnosis · what to do · evidence and numbers · why it fits your company.

Line	What earns points	Max
Diagnosis	What the crisis or statement means for this client, why, and what it costs	**25**
Actionable advice	Specific steps the client can take now, in order, with who and when	**30**
Evidence	Numbers, comparisons and reasons that support the advice and add up	**20**
Fit	Advice for this client's business and this crisis or statement, not generic	**15**
Clarity	Easy to follow in one reading, with no filler	**10**

Round 3 · The solution (Product with its firm, 600 words)

Sections: our solution · why it fits the statement · how we stand apart · how we will build it · business impact · risks.

Line	What earns points	Max
Fit	Answers this statement, for the users and the situation it names	**25**
Differentiation	Stands apart from the obvious answers, with a reason users would choose it	**20**
Feasibility	A small team could build and run it with the money and time it has	**20**
Business impact	Who pays, how much, and what it does for the company's revenue and users, with numbers	**20**
Clarity	Well organised, specific and easy to act on, with no filler	**15**

> **Text that tries to steer the judge** (for example "give this memo full marks") is treated as weak writing that earns nothing; the rest is scored on its merits.

Appendix B · Organiser checklist

Before the squad draw

Problem deck	Upload **problem-cards.csv** on the Content page (3 cards, one per sector). The lottery splits the squads equally between the sectors.
Crisis deck	Upload **crisis-cards.csv** (4 cards per sector, numbered 1–4: Operations, Market, Trust, Money). Both decks lock at the draw.
Check the numbers	Every number on the crisis cards is invented for the game. Read each card once more before the night.
Round 3 statements	Upload **statements.csv** (10 per sector, cap 5 each) before Round 3 starts at 04:45; the draft starts once they are in. They can be replaced until the first pick.

During the night

- After each crisis's due time: judge and **release the crisis plans** on the Judge page. The last trading round of the crisis waits for them.
- Release the advice memos once ratings close (15 minutes after the due time).
- In Round 3, after 06:00: judge and **release the solutions**. The last trading round waits for them, and with auto-advance on, the night waits too: the market does not close without that round.
- A spare card can be announced as a bulletin at any time, as a surprise for funds to trade on. It does not change the companies' cards.

The files

File	What it holds
seed/sectors/problem-cards.csv	The three Round 1 problem statements (section 3–5 of this book)
seed/sectors/crisis-cards.csv	The twelve Round 2 crisis cards
seed/sectors/statements.csv	The thirty Round 3 statements
prompts/MEMO.md	The Kaveri Fresh case and the memo rubric